FREE FAITH GUIDE

# Before the First *Mountain.*

CHOSEN BEFORE YOU COULD PERFORM A THING.



EPHESIANS 1

Chaotic Sunshine

# Before the first *mountain.*

Everything for one honest conversation: the lesson, the back story, the questions, memory cards and a coloring page.

1 · LESSON RECAP
2 · BACK STORY
3 · TALK IT THROUGH
4 · MEMORY CARDS
5 · COLORING PAGE

LESSON RECAP

## By 7 a.m. you're keeping score. God settled it before time began.

Most of us live as if God's choice gets renewed each morning based on the last 24 hours. Good day, He's pleased. Bad day, we brace. Paul places your chosenness before time itself: "For he chose us in him before the creation of the world" (Ephesians 1:4). You were chosen when you had done nothing at all, so your doing was never the reason. And Paul names the motive in two words: "In love."

THE WORD IN VERSE 4

***eklegomai***

GREEK · EK-LEG-OH-MY

To pick out, to select. Paul uses it for God choosing us "in him" before the world began (Ephesians 1:4).

| | *The scoreboard says* | *Ephesians 1 says* |
|---|---|---|
| WHEN | Renewed every morning, based on the last 24 hours | "Before the creation of the world" (1:4) |
| WHY | Because you performed well enough | "In love" (1:4-5) |
| COST | You keep paying, every day | Grace "freely given" (1:6), sins forgiven (1:7) |

***"For he chose us in him before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight."***

EPHESIANS 1:4 · NIV

TAKE THIS HOME

**I was chosen before I did a thing.**

PLOT TWIST

Paul wrote this from chains (Ephesians 6:20). A prisoner opens his letter by listing everything God already gave, before anyone did a thing to earn it.

the scoreboard doesn't get a vote.

THE BACK STORY

# Meanwhile, in Ephesus...

LETTER ID CARD

**Written by:** Paul, "an apostle of Christ Jesus" (1:1)
**Written to:** God's people in Ephesus (1:1)
**Written from:** Chains: "an ambassador in chains" (6:20)
**Format:** a letter; in Greek, 1:3-14 is one long sentence

a prisoner wrote the freest letter.

## What was going on

Ephesus was a busy port city in what is now Turkey, famous for the temple of Artemis. Silversmiths made good money selling her shrines (Acts 19:24-27).

Paul had spent about three years there (Acts 20:31). Later, as a prisoner (Ephesians 3:1; 4:1), he wrote back to remind them of everything they already had in Christ (1:3).

## Read verses 3 to 8 like a playlist

**1:3**
Blessed. Every spiritual blessing.

**1:4**
Chosen. Before the creation of the world.

**1:5-6**
Adopted and graced. "In love."

**1:7-8**
Redeemed. Grace lavished on us.

## Why it matters

In a city where blessing was bought and sold, Paul says every spiritual blessing is already ours in Christ (1:3).

"In love" (1:4-5) names the motive. Love came first. The choosing followed. Our doing comes after, as a response (2:10).

SO WHAT?

**Your chosenness is older than your worst day.**

and your best one.

IF THIS STIRS UP A LOT

If questions about your worth feel heavy, talking with a counselor, pastor or trusted friend is a strong, wise move. In a crisis, call or text 988.

TALK IT THROUGH · ABOUT 45 MINUTES

# Pull up a chair.

**BRING**
A snack, a pen and your honest self.

**WHO**
3 to 8 friends. "Pass" is always allowed.

**TABLE RULE**
What's shared here stays here.

**SPARK · 5 MIN**

### What did your morning scoreboard track today?

snacks count. host goes first.

**READ IT OUT LOUD · 5 MIN**

Read **Ephesians 1:3-8** together. Listen for every time God is the one doing the action. Count the "he"s.

**QUESTIONS · 25 MIN · START LIGHT, GO DEEPER**

1. Where did you learn to keep score with God? What does your scoreboard usually track?
2. Paul says God chose us "before the creation of the world" (1:4). Why does the timing matter so much?
3. Read 1:3-8 again. Which gift lands hardest for you: blessed, chosen, adopted, graced, redeemed or lavished?
4. Picture one morning lived as someone chosen before she had anything to offer. What changes first?
5. **Deep End:** Finish this sentence: "To stay in God's good favor, I feel like I have to..."

**CARD IT**
Write Ephesians 1:4 on a card (page 4). Read it at noon and at bedtime.

**SAY IT BACK**
Out loud, once a day: "I was chosen before I did a thing."

**PASS IT ON**
Tell one woman, by name, what you see God loving in her.

**CLOSE IN PRAYER**

***Lord, You chose us in Christ before the creation of the world. Let that settle the question we keep asking. Quiet the scoreboard in our heads, teach us to rest in Your love, and help us hand that love to the women around this table. Amen.***


**KEEP THE JOY COMING**

Get the Sunshine Mail.

One Sunday a month: Scripture, an honest reflection, and a little room for surprises.

Share your table on Instagram **@chaoticsunshinetable**.

**chaoticsunshine.com**

SCAN TO SIGN UP

# 4 • Memory verse cards

CUT ON THE DASHED LINES

MEMORY VERSE

***"For he chose us in him before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight."***

EPHESIANS 1:4 · NIV



MIRROR CARD

## Chosen *first.*

EPHESIANS 1:4 · NIV

tape me where you get ready.

POCKET REMINDER

**Chosen before I did a thing.**

This week: read Ephesians 1:4 at noon and bedtime, then tell one woman what you see God loving in her.

the scoreboard doesn't get a vote.

COLOR ME

Chosen first

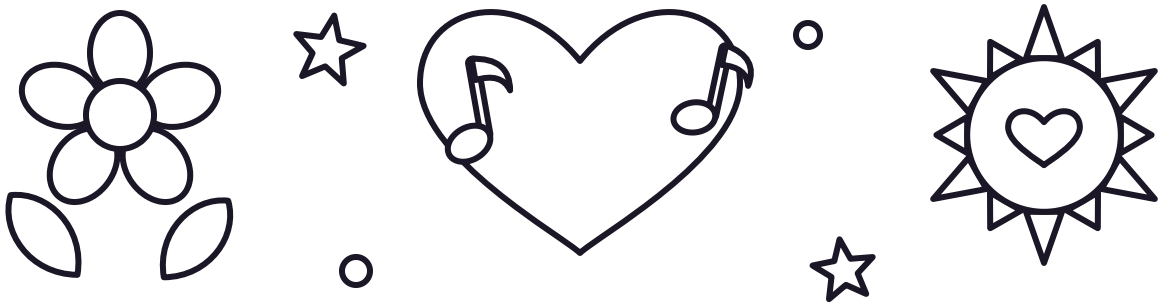
EPHESIANS 1:4 · NIV



# Chosen before I did a thing.

**...before the creation of the world...**

EPHESIANS 1:4 · NIV



**Margin Notes**

What I'd do if I stopped keeping score:

Sunshine Mail

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